Gates Foundation

Request For Proposal_Child Survival Campaign

Background/Context:

Jon Batiste summed it up: "***It's about love. In a time where the love of many has grown cold... What could come of a moment like this?***" May 8, 2025, Gates Foundation 25th Anniversary, NYC.

"The love of many has grown cold" may not be our usual language to describe current affairs, but it captures the essence of what our Gates Foundation communications strategy is trying to overcome. While the media landscape continues to fragment into a million algorithmic pieces, the prevailing narratives and the loudest voices paint a picture of a world where generosity and care for fellow humans is on the decline.

But we know that isn't true.

We get to work with amazing people all around the world who have dedicated their lives to helping others. Last year, the Gates Foundation committed to giving $200B in funding in the next 20 years to help our grantees and partners achieve **three incredibly ambitious goals:**

- No mom, baby or child dies of a preventable cause
- The next generation grows up in a world free of deadly infectious diseases
- Hundreds of millions more people move out poverty, putting countries on a path to prosperity

We know there are huge portions of the public who share the same values – that it's important to help others when they need it, regardless of where they live. This isn't wishful thinking. Our research shows that there is hope broadly – and in specific segments. New parents experience a surge of compassion for children and families around the world**.** People of faith demonstrate the core tenets of care for their neighbor and those less fortunate. Healthcare workers show up every day to help others and save lives, and they know that diseases have no borders. And ordinary people across all walks of life still care about each other, and the lives and wellbeing of people around the world.

We can win back hearts and minds. To do this, we need to engage with culture, and not just politics. We need to start local and go global. And we need to lead with values, and not just policy. These two things represent major changes to the way we work, and we need new partners to help us achieve that.

Winning hearts and minds will require a shift in our messaging, our campaigns, and our partners:

- In a world where everything seems politicized, we need to **lead with shared values,** including empathy, generosity, and a shared responsibility towards the vulnerable, especially children.
- In an attention-stretched media landscape, we need to **meet people where they are;** our campaigns will prioritize events, media platforms, and brands that are widely used and trusted by the public.
- As people turn from traditional media to influential individuals, we need to **bring in new voices**; our efforts must be amplified by trusted champions who reach the hearts and minds of millions.

- As people's trust in institutions declines, we need to find **new ways to tell the story of our work** and to make sure the first things someone hears about us are framed in terms of our core values.

Our goals for the communications division are simple, measurable, and challenging: Inspire more people to care about saving the lives of moms and babies, ending infectious diseases, and lifting people out of poverty, and build trust in the foundation to ensure we can continue to fund partners doing life-saving, life-improving work around the world.

We are in exploration mode. What stories and formats do we think will break through? Who shares these values? Which platforms, voices, moments and events have our audiences' attention and trust? What questions aren't we asking that we should? How do we build and sustain momentum?

Assignment:

We are developing a multi-year creative campaign to engage new audiences in high income countries to drive them to **care more about saving the lives of children around the world.** Most immediately, this will focus on new parents, with further audiences to come, as detailed below.

Our research suggests there are few more widely embraced values than the importance of saving children's lives. And yet, 4.8 million children die every year before their 5th birthdays from diseases that are preventable and treatable.

Moreover, (as highlighted in the 2025 Goalkeepers Report), for the first time since 2000, the number of child deaths increased last year, and projections show this number could continue to rise if cuts to development funding continue as projected. There has been pushback to this negative progress, but no general uproar. As our research suggests, child survival often falls off agendas due to other urgent problems or is dragged into politicization - and we are seeing that here.

And yet - the urge to protect a child is one of the strongest things we feel as humans. We need a groundswell of support that reflects how core that is to our humanity. We need a unifying "banner" that people from across the political spectrum can connect to that says we care about the lives of children, no matter where they live. And we believe in their potential – the amazing ideas and impact that happens when children can be healthy and thrive, get an education, build a livelihood, and contribute to their communities.

To note: Saving the lives of mothers is also a critical focus for the foundation and deeply connected to helping children to survive and thrive. We lean towards child survival as the focused, emotionally compelling "in" or "tip of the spear" for this campaign but will be open to thoughts from agencies on this focus and balance.

This campaign will be a sustained effort over a minimum 3 – 5-year timeframe. To have a real impact, this effort cannot rely on marketing tactics. It must provide a unifying idea that can motivate new parents (and additional target audiences) across the political spectrum, as well as key partners from across sectors (NGO, charity, private, entertainment, etc.) to come alongside and drive it forward with us.

Ultimate success is that target public audiences are inspired, engaged and mobilized, and this ladders up to putting pressure on decision-makers to commit to our three core goals above and the importance of funding for saving children's lives.

Campaign Objective:

Get: New parents in select donor countries (UK, US, and Germany)

To: Care about all children living to their 5th birthdays

By: Using a values-based, multi-channel approach to inspire a sense of connection and conviction about the importance of children surviving to the age of five, no matter where they are born.

Priority Audiences:

Primary: New parents in the UK, US, and Germany

Longer-term: We are open to ideas about how to broaden this campaign to other segments of the public and a wider set of countries that might be engaged in saving the lives of kids around the world. Other audience segments we are currently considering include health workers, people of faith, engaged youth and tech and science workers.

Audience Insight:

Preliminary research from primary and secondary sources confirm that new parents experience a surge of empathy when they first have a child. Any new parent will tell you that those first months and years are a blur. But our research shows that these are also years when people experience an increase in propensity to care about not just their own child, but the lives of children everywhere. This campaign aims to tap into that sense of compassion and connection.

But it won't be easy. We know that while people care, they often have other more pressing concerns on their minds that they care *more* about - cost of living, job security, and a constant barrage of bad news about events and politics across the world. New parents are more worried about their children's futures today than in previous generations – and that concern can be all-encompassing.

KPIs: Initial KPIs below; to be confirmed during campaign design:

- # of actions taken by target audiences, including donations to local and global health charities at certain moments, shares, and amplification of campaign messages on social media.
- >+10% concern/prioritization among target audiences for child health issues
- >40% target audience penetration
- % content engagement rates exceed industry benchmarks
- Message pull-through, volume, and sentiment in earned media and organic social content
- # of credible, authentic partners who join to drive the campaign alongside us
- Total viewership and engagement of creative partnership outputs

Calendar/Key Moments:

- **Q2 – Q3 2026:** Audience research, creative concepting, campaign design, media planning & buying
- **Q4 2026:** Campaign kick-off in target regions

To note – potential focus moments:

- **March-June:** Mother's Day (UK, US)
- **July-September:** Back to School (Germany, US)
- **October-December:** Thanksgiving (US)
- **October-December:** Christmas (Germany, UK, US)

What we're looking for in an agency partner:

We are in exploration mode. The audience insights and guidance above should be a starting point, but not a limiting factor. Please bring your biggest and best ideas, even if they fall slightly outside the brief.

This will be a collaborative effort. Bring your best people and partners—whether that's your own team or a group of firms you love working with and think would be a strong fit for this campaign. We're looking for creative minds who know how to collaborate and build on each other's strengths.

We will evaluate agencies/teams based on the following parameters:

- **Local depth, regional cohesion:** Should demonstrate the ability to develop a consistent creative concept across key donor markets, with local expertise in the UK, US and Germany.
- **Creative leadership:** Must help us find a powerful creative idea that can create a consistent, lasting impact with our key audiences. We're also looking for strong ideas on meaningful CTAs, which connect to the values of the campaign, the motivations and behaviors of our target audiences, and can help cement longer-lasting support for these issues.
- **Creative collaboration:** Must have proven experience acting as a lead for creative vision within a team of partner organizations across regions. Demonstrated ability to support great ideas without ego or territorial behavior is critical.
- **Understanding of non-profit space:** Must have an understanding of the complexity of building a brand in the philanthropic/non-profit space.
- **Alignment with our mission/values:** We cannot engage with agencies whose activities conflict with our mission and values. Please refer to this page for more detail on this requirement and disclose any activities/clients we may need to be aware of (e.g. tobacco clients).

If agencies can't meet all requirements of this brief, we're interested in responses that describe where they feel their strengths are and/or areas where they would look to partner with others.

Scope of Services:

We are seeking a creative agency to engage in creative concepting, campaign design, and some campaign production:

- **Creative concepting:** We are looking for a range of creative concepts that outline a new "big idea" that we can leverage to drive conversation and inspiration with key audiences. Ideas should have legs across all paid, owned, earned, and partner channels.
- **Campaign design:** We are looking for a new vision for how to engage our priority audience segments. How do we create "surround sound" in today's fragmented media landscape? How do we break through on a low-salience topic in comparison to other urgent issues facing our audiences? What established channels should we still rely on? What new voices, platforms, and partnerships should we consider? What types of CTAs will be most meaningful/impactful? Agency should take an audience-led, data-driven approach to identifying the engagement strategies and channels that we need. Agency should also provide ideas on which existing organizations they will work with/we should partner with to ensure this campaign is sustainable.
- **Campaign production:** We will work with a variety of vendors to execute the campaign, based on capabilities and cost. We want to understand the range of your expertise, your global footprint and capabilities in priority markets, and the ballpark costs for any tactics you believe you are well positioned to produce. We expect that this agency partner will, at minimum, produce our core creative assets, including video content, visual content, and any other assets needed for paid media.

Specific Project Deliverables

See below for a sense of high-level project elements as you consider a workplan and budget for the pitch presentation. We invite each agency to share what they see as the key project deliverables in addition to these.

- **Capabilities overview and relevant case studies:** Provide a thorough understanding of your agency's capabilities, what you deliver in-house and where you partner, and 3 – 5 case studies of multi-channel campaigns in our priority countries. To the extent possible, we want to understand what you produced and where you partnered to bring these campaigns to life – what went well, what was challenging, how did the idea evolve as it went from concept to execution, etc.
- **Project plan:** Outline of the phases of the effort and expected timelines for major deliverables (including go-live dates for new content).
- **Creative concepts & campaign design:** Development of a set of concepts to consider for new creative, including local creative, media and advocacy partner ideas, focus channels, and audience engagement ideas and clear rationale.
- **Country-specific workshops:** Set of meetings with colleagues across local markets to weigh options and prioritize concepts.
- **Creative development:** Creative/content development and revisions. Full creative content asset list to be confirmed in collaboration with our creative partners but would likely include video "hero" assets.

- **Campaign planning:** Collaboration with paid media partner(s) to integrate creative ideas and media plan into detailed campaign plan. Collaboration with key partners to bring creative ideas to life across the partner ecosystem in a sustained cadence.
- **Content production and launch:** Final drafts of creative content produced according to channel/media plan specifications.

Timing. The RFP process will have four key milestones:

March 16: Expression of interest and optional Q&A calls, which will be joint calls (all agencies invited) offered in two one-hour sessions. We will follow up on specific times.

April 1: Submit written capabilities, case studies, and initial campaign ideas. We will then narrow to 3 finalists for live pitch presentations.

Week of April 20th: 45-minute optional early concept review and check-in. We are willing to meet and review early concepts in development and discuss direction and feedback in preparation for final pitches. We think this emulates a client-agency relationship more effectively than pitch presentations alone.

Weeks of April 27/May 4th: 60-minute pitch presentations. We expect that agencies will come prepared to describe the creative ideas and competencies they believe will be necessary to tackle this campaign effectively. For this proposal, we ask each agency to share the following:

- **Creative Ideas:** 2-3 creative concepts for the campaign as described above.
- **Campaign Executions**: Illustrative examples of how campaign ideas come to life across channels and across key campaign markets. To consider:
    - Global tagline
    - Manifesto video
    - Print/OOH examples
    - Digital/social examples
    - Employee communications
    - Owned channel examples (implementation on website, The Optimist, and other key channels)
    - Partner communications
    - CTAs
- **Team composition:** A list of staff who will be assigned to the project, as well as short bios and an overview of their role on this project
- **Regional/local working model:** How you would approach developing this campaign, detailing how regional and local teams would engage throughout the creative development process.
- **Workplan:** A high-level workplan, including the estimated time necessary for each step. For all timeframes, please keep in mind the need to consult with a wide set of stakeholders at the foundation (we typically require minimum 5 business days for consolidated feedback in each creative round).

- **Budget:** Estimated budget for the process, with costs broken down by project phase, including a high-level recommendation on fees vs production. We understand production fees may vary based on the creative concept and decisions made in the creative process.
- **DOES NOT INCLUDE**: Media planning and buying are not included in this RFP. We are interested in engaging with a partner that can work collaboratively with our existing media agencies, including MediaHub and other local media partners, as needed.